

# BUS 123 - Solving Business Problems with Technology

INTRO-M01-L02

BUS 123 — INTRO-M01-L02 — Technology Orientation & Technology in Business

PRE-READING

## BUS 123 — INTRO-M01-L02 — Technology Orientation & Technology in Business

### BUS 123 · INTRO-M01-L02 · TECHNOLOGY ORIENTATION & TECHNOLOGY IN BUSINESS

**Course:** Solving Business Problems with Technology · Fall 2026 **Track:** INTRO · **Module:** M01 · **Lessons:** L02-L03

### CONNECT TO PRIOR KNOWLEDGE

This is the first reading lesson of BUS123 — Solving Business Problems with Technology. You are beginning with a clean slate, which means the prior knowledge here is the everyday digital experience you already bring to the room: using a smartphone, saving files to a computer, logging into a school portal.

This combined reading builds directly on that familiarity. First, you will set up the Microsoft 365 and OneDrive habits needed for the course. Then you will step back and ask a sharper question: **are you using these tools casually, or professionally?** By the end of this module, you will have the foundation to answer confidently.

### WHAT IS MICROSOFT 365?

Microsoft 365 is a subscription-based suite of productivity software that includes Excel, Word, PowerPoint, OneDrive, Outlook, and Teams. As an Endicott student, you have **full access at no cost** through your college account — which includes installing the desktop applications on up to five personal devices.

| Application | Primary Purpose                                  | Used In BUS123                               |
|-------------|--------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| Excel       | Numerical data, calculations, financial analysis | Primary tool — every module                  |
| Word        | Professional documents, reports, memos           | Selected written deliverables                |
| PowerPoint  | Presentations, pitch decks, visual communication | Final project and selected activities        |
| OneDrive    | Cloud storage and file sync across all devices   | Required for all file storage and submission |

### WHAT IS ONEDRIVE?

OneDrive is Microsoft's cloud storage and synchronization service. When you save a file to your OneDrive folder on your laptop, it is automatically copied to Microsoft's servers and made available on every other device connected to the same account.

This means:

- You can never truly "lose" the file to a dead laptop — it lives in the cloud.

- - Every device stays current — edit on your phone and the changes appear on your laptop.
- - Sharing is a link, not an attachment — colleagues can see the live version, never a stale copy.
- - Version history is automatic — OneDrive saves prior versions so you can roll back mistakes.

### Endicott-Specific Detail

Your Endicott College Microsoft account includes **1 TB of OneDrive storage**. This is separate from any personal Microsoft account you may already have. Always confirm you are signed in to your **@mail.endicott.edu** account — not a personal Hotmail or Outlook.com account — before saving course files.

## INSTALLING AND ACTIVATING MICROSOFT 365

If you have not already installed the desktop applications, follow these steps using your Endicott student credentials:

1. Go to **portal.office.com** and sign in with your **@endicott.edu** email address.
2. Click **Install apps** in the top right corner and select **Microsoft 365 apps**.
3. Run the downloaded installer and follow the on-screen prompts.
4. Open any Office app (Excel, Word, or PowerPoint), go to **File** → **Account**, and confirm your Endicott email appears under **User Information**.
5. If you see a different account, click **Sign Out**, then **Sign In** with your **@mail.endicott.edu** address.

### ⚠ Common Mistake

Students who already have a personal Microsoft account often find that OneDrive syncs to the wrong account. Before saving any course file, verify that the account shown in **File** → **Account** is your **@mail.endicott.edu** address — not a personal account. Files saved to a personal OneDrive are not accessible to your instructor.

## SETTING UP YOUR BUS123 FOLDER STRUCTURE IN ONEDRIVE

Consistent folder organization is a professional habit, not a preference. In BUS123, all files should be saved inside a specific folder structure in your Endicott OneDrive to allow you to find and upload assignments easily. A recommended folder structure, that aligns with the class modules in Canvas is listed below:

| Folder Level       | Name                 | What Goes Here                          |
|--------------------|----------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| 1 — Top level      | BUS123               | Everything for this course              |
| 2 — Subfolders     | INTRO / EXCEL / MATH | One folder per track                    |
| 3 — Module folders | M01 , M02 , M03 ...  | One folder per module within each track |

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## FILE NAMING CONVENTION

Every file you save/upload in BUS123 must follow the course naming convention. This makes it easy to identify, sort, and share your work without confusion.

**Format:** LastName\_FirstName\_BUS123\_ModuleN.xlsx

**Example:** Evitts\_Bethany\_BUS123\_Module01.xlsx

### Why This Matters

I receive dozens of files with names like `homework.xlsx` or `final_FINAL_v3.xlsx`. A properly named file tells me exactly who submitted it and what it contains — before it is even opened. This is a professional habit that carries into every workplace. Get in that habit now.

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## SAVING, SYNCING, AND VERIFYING A FILE

Saving a file to your OneDrive folder is not the same as the file being available in the cloud. There is a brief delay between saving locally and the file completing its upload to Microsoft's servers. **Always verify sync status before submitting.**

| Sync Icon                                                                                            | What It Means                     | What to Do                                 |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
|  Blue circle/arrows | File is currently uploading       | Wait — do not submit yet                   |
|  Green checkmark   | File is fully synced to the cloud | Safe to copy share link and submit         |
|  Red X            | Sync error — file did not upload  | Check your internet connection and re-save |

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## KEY VOCABULARY: MICROSOFT 365 & ONEDRIVE

| Term                          | Definition                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|-------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Microsoft 365</b>          | A subscription-based suite of productivity applications including Excel, Word, PowerPoint, OneDrive, Outlook, and Teams. Endicott students have full access at no cost through their college credentials. |
| <b>OneDrive</b>               | Microsoft's cloud storage and file synchronization service. Files saved to OneDrive are automatically backed up to remote servers and accessible across all signed-in devices.                            |
| <b>Cloud Storage</b>          | Files stored on remote servers accessed over the internet rather than on a physical hard drive. Enables multi-device access and protects against local hardware failure.                                  |
| <b>Sync</b>                   | The process of ensuring the local copy of a file and the cloud copy are identical and up to date. Indicated by a green checkmark on the file icon in your OneDrive folder.                                |
| <b>Desktop Application</b>    | A software program installed and running directly on your computer, as opposed to a browser-based version. Desktop apps have full features and work offline.                                              |
| <b>File Naming Convention</b> | A standardized format for naming files so they are identifiable, sortable, and consistent. BUS123 format: <code>LastName_FirstName_BUS123_ModuleN.xlsx</code> .                                           |
| <b>Activation</b>             | The process of signing in to Microsoft 365 with your Endicott credentials to unlock full access to the desktop applications. Verified under File → Account in any Office app.                             |
| <b>Version History</b>        | OneDrive's automatic record of prior saved states of a file. Allows you to restore an earlier version if content is accidentally deleted or overwritten.                                                  |

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## WHY TECHNOLOGY MATTERS IN BUSINESS

In the first lessons of BUS123 you installed Microsoft 365, set up your OneDrive folder structure, and learned what this course is and how it works. You now have the tools and the expectations.

This lesson asks a sharper question: **why does any of it matter?** Before you learn how to build a payroll model or analyze inventory data, it helps to understand the larger context — how technology actually functions inside a business, and what separates someone who uses it casually from someone who uses it professionally.

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## PASSIVE USER VS. PROFESSIONAL OPERATOR

Most people interact with technology every day without thinking about it deliberately. A **passive user** opens an app, does a task, and closes it. A **professional operator** thinks about what output the tool needs to produce, how to structure the work so others can verify it, and how to catch errors before they matter.

| Dimension       | Passive User                           | Professional Operator                                  |
|-----------------|----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------|
| Goal            | Complete the task                      | Produce reliable output someone else can use           |
| File management | Saves wherever is convenient           | Follows a naming and folder convention every time      |
| Formula use     | Types answers directly into cells      | References input cells so results update automatically |
| Error response  | Deletes the error and retypes a number | Traces the formula to find and fix the root cause      |
| Sharing         | Emails an attachment                   | Shares a live OneDrive link to the current version     |

### The Shift This Course Is Asking You to Make

You do not need to be an expert to be a professional operator. You need to be **deliberate**. The habits you build in BUS123 — naming files correctly, using formulas instead of typed values, checking your work before submitting — are the same habits that make a junior analyst trustworthy to a manager.

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## TECHNOLOGY ACROSS BUSINESS SECTORS

Every industry uses technology differently, but the underlying skills are transferable. Understanding how technology shows up in the work you are heading toward helps you know which tools to prioritize.

| Sector                | Core Technology Problem                                           | BUS123 Connection                          |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| Retail                | Tracking inventory costs, pricing products, managing markdowns    | COGS, markup/markdown, inventory math      |
| Professional Services | Calculating employee compensation, modeling client loan scenarios | Payroll, TVM, interest calculations        |
| Event Management      | Projecting breakeven, managing seasonal cash gaps                 | Breakeven analysis, cash flow modeling     |
| Healthcare            | Analyzing payer mix, managing complex multi-rate payroll          | Data analysis, payroll with variable rates |
| Finance               | Modeling loan payments, evaluating investment returns             | TVM, PMT, FV/PV functions                  |

## THE DIGITAL FLUENCY SPECTRUM

Employers think about digital skills in layers. Knowing where you currently sit on this spectrum — and where you want to be — helps you set a goal for what BUS123 can do for you.

| Level                     | Description                                                        | What It Looks Like                                                    |
|---------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 — Basic User            | Can open, navigate, and save files in standard applications        | Types text in Word, opens spreadsheets, attaches files to email       |
| 2 — Functional User       | Uses built-in tools to complete defined tasks reliably             | Writes SUM formulas, formats a table, builds a basic chart            |
| 3 — Professional Operator | Structures work so it is accurate, auditable, and maintainable     | Builds referenced formulas, names files correctly, checks for errors  |
| 4 — Analytical Producer   | Uses technology to answer business questions and support decisions | Builds a payroll model, runs a breakeven analysis, interprets results |

### ✓ Where BUS123 Targets You

Most students enter at Level 1 or 2. BUS123 is designed to move you to **Level 3** by the end of the EXCEL track and to **Level 4** by the end of the MATH track. Level 4 is where early-career business roles are won.

## HOW TECHNOLOGY SHAPES DECISIONS

A spreadsheet does not just execute a calculation you already know how to do. It changes what questions you can even ask.

Consider a retail buyer deciding how many units to order. Without a model, the decision is a guess. With a properly built spreadsheet, the buyer can run ten scenarios in two minutes and identify the order quantity that minimizes risk under each one.

This is the core reason BUS123 exists: **technology does not replace business judgment — it amplifies it.** The analyst who can build the model gets to participate in the decision. The one who cannot has to wait for someone else's output.

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## WHERE AI FITS IN

AI tools, including tools like Microsoft Copilot, Claude, and ChatGPT in Excel and Word, are increasingly present in business workflows. It is worth being honest about what they do and do not change.

| AI Is Good At                                 | AI Is Not Good At                                                 |
|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Drafting a first version of something         | Knowing whether the answer is correct for your specific situation |
| Summarizing large amounts of text             | Catching errors in a formula it did not write                     |
| Suggesting functions you did not know existed | Understanding the business context behind the numbers             |
| Automating repetitive formatting tasks        | Taking responsibility for a wrong result                          |

### The Skill AI Cannot Replace

AI tools are most valuable to people who **already know how to do the work**. If you cannot read a formula and judge whether it is correct, you cannot evaluate what AI produces. BUS123 builds the foundation that makes AI useful rather than dangerous.

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## TECHNOLOGY HABITS THAT PAY OFF

The research on early-career outcomes consistently shows that digital skill gaps are one of the most common reasons recent graduates underperform expectations. The habits below are simple — but most students do not practice them until they learn the hard way.

**Name every file correctly, every time.** File naming is not a preference. It is a professional standard. An improperly named file signals carelessness before the content is even opened.

**Save to the cloud, not the device.** Local saves are one hardware failure away from lost work. Cloud saves are versioned, backed up, and accessible from anywhere.

**Use formulas, not typed values.** A typed number in a result cell is invisible to the next person who opens the file. A formula is a documented, auditable calculation.

**Check your output before you share it.** Sending a file with a formula error is worse than sending it late. Spend two minutes reviewing before submitting anything.

**Learn the keyboard shortcut for what you do most.** Speed compounds. Ten seconds saved per task adds up to hours across a semester — and across a career.

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## KEY VOCABULARY: TECHNOLOGY IN BUSINESS

| Term                            | Definition                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Passive User</b>             | Someone who uses technology reactively to complete a task without thinking deliberately about structure, accuracy, or how others will use the output.                                                        |
| <b>Professional Operator</b>    | Someone who uses technology deliberately to produce reliable, auditable, and maintainable output that others can depend on.                                                                                  |
| <b>Digital Fluency</b>          | The ability to use digital tools effectively and appropriately across a range of business contexts. Fluency implies understanding, not just task completion.                                                 |
| <b>Digital Fluency Spectrum</b> | A four-level framework describing how technology competence develops: from basic user through functional user, professional operator, to analytical producer.                                                |
| <b>Analytical Producer</b>      | The highest level of the digital fluency spectrum. An analytical producer uses technology to answer business questions, model scenarios, and support decisions rather than execute predefined tasks.         |
| <b>Formula Integrity</b>        | The property of a spreadsheet in which all calculated values are produced by formulas referencing input cells, making the model auditable, updateable, and free of hard-coded values in result cells.        |
| <b>Microsoft Copilot</b>        | An AI assistant built into Microsoft 365 applications including Excel and Word. Useful for drafting, summarizing, and suggesting functions — but requires the user to evaluate and verify all output.        |
| <b>Payer Mix</b>                | In healthcare finance, the proportion of revenue coming from different payment sources such as private insurance, Medicare, Medicaid, and self-pay patients. Used in Harborside Medical Center case studies. |